Car Rental Marketplace: Roadmap from Scratch

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Phase 1: Define the business (1-2 weeks)

This is a two-sided marketplace (like Turo, Airbnb or Zoomcar), so settle the business model and legal footing before writing code.

1. **Decide the model.** Owners list cars and you take a commission (typically 10-25%) per booking. Decide early whether you handle payments and payouts, or only connect owners and customers.
2. **Research competitors.** Study Zoomcar, Drivezy, Turo and local players in Indore. Note what they do poorly.
3. **Pick a launch city.** Marketplaces fail when spread thin. Launch in one city so you get enough cars and customers in the same place.
4. **Sort out legal basics** (this matters in India):
    - Business registration (Pvt Ltd or LLP) and GST
    - Rental cars need commercial/yellow-plate registration or specific permits, so check Motor Vehicles Act rules for self-drive rentals in your state
    - Insurance: commercial insurance for rental use, plus a damage/accident policy
    - Terms of service, owner agreement and a damage/dispute policy
5. **Define your MVP.** Only the features needed to complete one booking end to end.

Phase 2: Plan the product (1-2 weeks)

List only the features an MVP needs to complete one booking, split by who uses them.

Owner side

- Sign up and KYC (ID, bank details)
- Add a car: photos, RC book, insurance, location, price per day, availability calendar
- Approve or reject bookings, see earnings

Customer side

- Sign up, upload driving license (verification)
- Search and filter: city, dates, price, car type, transmission, fuel, seats
- Car detail page, book, pay, view bookings

- Reviews and ratings

Admin side

- Approve cars and users, manage bookings, handle disputes, track commission

Key design decisions

- Booking logic: avoid double-booking, define cancellation rules, security deposit, fuel/km policy, late-return penalties
- Instant booking vs. owner approval

Then sketch wireframes (Figma is free) for the main screens: home/search, results, car page, checkout, owner dashboard.

Phase 3: Choose your tech stack

A solid, beginner-friendly stack is Next.js with a Node or Django backend on PostgreSQL.

Layer	Option
Frontend	Next.js (React) + Tailwind CSS
Backend	Node.js (Express/NestJS) or Django
Database	PostgreSQL (good for date-range availability queries)
Auth	Clerk, Firebase Auth, or NextAuth
Image storage	Cloudinary or AWS S3
Payments	Razorpay (supports split payments/payouts via Razorpay Route)
Maps/location	Google Maps API
Notifications	Email (Resend) + SMS/WhatsApp (Twilio, MSG91)
Hosting	Vercel (frontend) + Railway/Render/AWS (backend, DB)

For the fastest route, Next.js + Supabase (Postgres + auth + storage) covers a lot with little backend code.

Phase 4: Design the database

Eight main tables cover the MVP, and availability checking is the hardest part.

- **users**: role (customer / owner / admin), KYC status
- **cars**: owner_id, make, model, year, fuel, transmission, seats, price, location, status
- **car_images**
- **availability / blocked_dates**
- **bookings**: car_id, customer_id, start/end datetime, total price, status, payment_id
- **payments**: amount, commission, payout status
- **reviews**
- **documents**: license, RC, insurance

A car is available only if no confirmed booking overlaps the requested dates. Handle this with database transactions so two people cannot book the same car.

Phase 5: Build in this order (6-10 weeks solo)

Build one feature end to end before starting the next.

1. Project setup, database, authentication, user roles
2. Owner flow: add/edit car with image upload
3. Public car listing page with search and filters
4. Car detail page with availability calendar
5. Booking flow and price calculation
6. Payment integration (start in Razorpay test mode)
7. Dashboards for owner and customer
8. Admin panel (approve cars, manage bookings)
9. Email/SMS notifications
10. Reviews and ratings

Phase 6: Test and launch

Launch small: onboard 10-20 cars manually before inviting customers.

- Test edge cases: overlapping bookings, cancellations, failed payments, refunds
- Check security: input validation, protected routes, never store card data yourself
- Make it mobile-friendly, since most users will book from phones
- Soft launch with friends and local owners first, then invite customers
- Add basic analytics (Google Analytics, Hotjar)

Phase 7: Grow

Get owners first, then customers, so searches never come back empty.

- Solve the chicken-and-egg problem: attract owners with a guarantee (for example, a free first month with no commission), then run local marketing to customers
- Collect reviews, improve search, and add a mobile app later
- Consider damage protection plans, GPS tracking and doorstep delivery as differentiators

Practical advice

Do not build everything at once; supply, trust, insurance and support matter as much as code.

- Skip chat, mobile apps and complex pricing until you have real bookings.
- If you are not a developer, hire a freelancer or use a marketplace builder like Sharetribe to validate the idea faster, then rebuild custom later.
- Budget time for the non-tech work: owner onboarding, insurance, dispute handling and customer support.